

The Future of Telephony: OPEN SOURCE PBX

The story of Linux eating into the operating systems market is going to repeat with open-source Asterisk platform for PBXes. Here is a step-by-step tour of how to install and configure Asterisk as an IP PBX



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The PC world has seen and benefited from two disruptive movements: multivendor approach for hardware and open source development in software. Till IBM came out with an open architecture for PCs, PCs and their components could be purchased only from the manufacturers of complete PCs, like IBM and Apple. IBM changed this landscape, and at the same time, open source developments such as Linux torpedoed the software landscape.

Today, the PBX world is seeing both these phenomena combined together in one movement called Asterisk which is going to revolutionise the PBX landscape. The story of Linux eating into the operating systems market is going to repeat with Asterisk and PBXes.

What is Asterisk?

Mark Spencer, founder of a company called Digium, wrote the code for a soft switch and gave it to the world as an open source project. This was the birth of Asterisk and also the start of a revolution which would

change the telephony landscape in the coming years. The community under the patronage of Digium has converted Asterisk into a very powerful platform that can host a wide variety of applications like IP PBXes, dialers, prepaid calling card platforms and transit switches (Class 4 switch). The versatility of the platform and the open source nature will enable Asterisk to be present in all venues of telephony in the next decade.

Asterisk and PBXes

A closer look into the IP PBX market—one of the main applications of Asterisk—gives an indepth view of the power of the Asterisk platform.

Currently, the global PBX market, comprising traditional, hybrid and IP PBXes, is worth \$6.4 billion and it is going to grow to \$15 billion in 2012. Interestingly, traditional PBX sales are on the decline, and hybrid PBX sales will start declining in 2010. On the other hand, the IP telephony market in India is growing at 25 per cent annually and is expected to reach \$367 million in 2010.

In a gist, this statistical data shows that the PBX continues to be a growing market and therefore an interesting market to be in. Asterisk, with its flexibility to be deployed as a hybrid PBX as well as pure IP PBX, is well positioned to